



THE VOICE EXPRESS

*The Truth Takes Time.*

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INTERNATIONAL

# "It's Okay, They're Just Playing With Us": Games of the Gun from the Occupied West Bank

*A report on a practice documented in the occupied West Bank, where soldiers from Israeli settlements use laser sights from sniper rifles to play 'statue' with Palestinian families — forcing people to freeze on command. On the mundane, psychological texture of long-term military occupation.*

BY MOULI SHARMA

16 JULY 2024 · 6 MIN READ



ABOUT

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EDITOR IN CHIEF

**Mouli**

WEB DEVELOPER

**Mitali (Aayat Mahnoor)**

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CONTACT

**thevoiceexpress@proton.me**

---

WEBSITE

**<https://thevoiceexpress.in>**

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LOCATION

**New Delhi, India**

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INDEPENDENT • VOLUNTEER-RUN

VOL. 18 • EST. 2022

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*"I visited my sister in her home in Beit Ummar, which is a village in Hebron. Sitting atop a hill their beautiful home was surrounded by three Israeli settlements. I woke up in the middle of the night with my nephew & brother-in-law standing next to me - they'd spotted several laser pointers pointing into the house from one of the settlements that are nearby. And when I asked them what was happening, they told me to stay lying in bed because this is often a game that settlers played with them. The "game" was laser pointers from sniper rifles in the house at all times, so they knew that they could take a shot whenever they wanted."*  
- @candide\_freeman on TikTok, posted 22nd October 2023, with 5 likes & 1 share.

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*"Soldiers are bored. They're just maybe sitting there & they kinda want to mess with you. You feel like a hamster sitting in a test wheel. They're just playing with you." - Leila Warah, AJStream on Al Jazeera, 16th July, 2024.*

**P**ost '67, Pockets of Palestine Surrounded by Israeli Settlements Have Learnt to Live with a Strange & Psychologically Grotesque Consequence of Long-Term Military Occupation: Bored Soldiers.

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**16th July 2024, New Delhi:** On October 22nd, 2023, a mere two weeks after October 7th, a video was posted to TikTok showing a man describing a visit to his sister's home in a small Hebron village called Beit Ummar, & their life along the occupied West Bank. He described a game the soldiers played with Palestinian families in the area, explained to him by his own nephew and brother-in-law. It was a game of 'statue', as people who grew up in parts of the world not under active warfare would recall playing, where a group of runners freezes up in response to a commanding catcher, yelling out the preferred variant of the band of neighborhood rascals: Ice! Freeze! Lock! Tag! Statue!

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In Beit Ummar, the command is not heard but seen, in the form of laser pointers from sniper rifles. And the soldiers always chase.

*"I visited my sister in her home in Beit Ummar, which is a village in Hebron. Sitting atop a hill their beautiful home was surrounded by three Israeli settlements. I woke up in the middle of the night with my nephew & brother-in-law standing next to me - they'd spotted several laser pointers pointing into the house from one of the settlements that are nearby. And when I asked them what was happening, they told me to stay lying in bed because this is often a game that settlers played with them. The "game" was laser pointers from sniper rifles in the house at all times, so they knew that they could take a shot whenever they wanted." - @candide\_freeman on TikTok, posted 22nd October 2023, with 5 likes & 1 share.*

Journalist Leila Warah (@leila.shw on Instagram) describes this phenomenon as a common, almost ordinary occurrence in areas like Beit Ummar, which are populated by native residents leftover after the Six Day War back in '67, outnumbered & surrounded by Israeli settlements. An evolved form of settler violence, born less from malice or urgency, and - rather terrifyingly - more from boredom.

Areas with a larger displaced population - & consequently stronger military presence - on the other hand, like refugee camps & epicenters of post-October 7th attacks see their own versions of these 'second-person shooter games'. Drones flying up to balconies & uttering eerily human threats in distinctly unhuman voices ("We are in wartime," says a drone to an elderly man while hovering outside his balcony. "We advise you to take caution. And take care of your kids. Whoever thinks of doing something, we will get to him. We are in wartime..."), remote-controlled guns that seem to track movement; air-dropped aid that kills.<sup>[1]</sup>

In Aida Refugee Camp, where Leila Warah lives & works, daily life looks very different from that in Beit Ummar. Like most refugee camps, the overwhelming presence around Aida is not that of settlers but of soldiers. The UNRWA recognises 58 Palestinian camps (not including 10 more formed after '67) across the occupied land, & even among them, Aida is highly surveilled<sup>[2]</sup>.

At the entrance of this camp sits a remote-controlled gun. One that points at every passerby, & is triggered by untested artificial intelligence<sup>[3]</sup>.

*"I've gone up to it to film a couple of times, but this is a relatively dangerous area," Warah begins, elaborating on her personal encounters with the notorious firearm on Al Jazeera's The Stream. "Soldiers are bored. They're just maybe sitting there & they kinda want to mess with you. I've gone up there to film the remote-controlled gun - all I'm carrying is a camera - & I see the gun just kind of... twist & turn towards me, where it's pointed directly at me." She tells the story like she's told it a million times before.*

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She says it like it bores her.

Because of course, in a state that's been on lockdown for 75 years, it isn't just the soldiers who have nothing to do.

In *Siri Miri*<sup>[4]</sup>, a Palestinian short film about youth & boredom in a 21st-century apartheid nation directed by Luay Awwad<sup>[5]</sup>, a sniper rifle being pointed at two teenagers enjoying a bonfire is treated as little more than a joke, and one that's low-hanging fruit at that. The scene seems to jab at the casualty of the encounter, glossing over the drama of a near-death experience in favor of that of a torched Friday night plan, as if the snipers are just mischievous old coots outside of the frame, teasing our boys as they skulk off in defeat. A cartoonish nemeses, with cartoonish gravity.

The scene speaks to the peaceful global resident something so foreign they can do little more than scoff at the absurdity of it all; offering sympathy where it isn't needed, & will be unflinchingly rejected. 'Feel sorry that the fucker ruined our bonfire again,' Awwad says in his film. 'There's nothing else for you to feel sorry about.'

What is interesting about *Siri Miri* is that contrary to popular understanding of freedoms & everyday life in Palestine before October 7th, the film was released in 2021, long before Netanyahu's military campaign in the region, & the degree of infrastructural control shown in it (water, movement, electricity, rations, safety) is far from the worst exercised by Israel in the West Bank, either in the past or in the present.

*"Take care of your kids." - Israeli Drone Outside Palestinian Family's Balcony, @yumna.hp on TikTok, 3rd December 2023.*

There's a sadistic sense of humour with which the Israeli military has come to operate in Palestine, a humour that could only have evolved from a relationship of violence, control, & colonisation that has lasted half a century. A disturbing intimacy to the familiarity with which Israeli soldiers point their guns at Palestinians; a reverse Stockholm syndrome between keeper & kept, as if the terror they cause is but a drawn-out abusive marriage they don't recognise themselves outside of. 'What do they mean they don't want to be tortured & killed? What do they mean they don't want to have their homes stolen & bombed? What do they mean they don't love my boot on their neck?'

*What do you mean you don't want to play?*

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*Based on Leila Warah's interview aired alongside curated TikTok posts on The Stream hosted by Anelise Borges on Al Jazeera (English) on 16th July 2024. Report compiled by The Voice Express.*

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



## Mouli Sharma

CONTRIBUTOR

Mouli Sharma is a journalist, freelance illustrator, and writer from New Delhi, India. She is a published photojournalist & illustrator, having been featured in The Hindu College Gazette, & the quarterly Pink Disco. Mouli took over as the Editor of The Voice Express (<https://thevoiceexpress.github.io/e-mag/>) back in September 2023.

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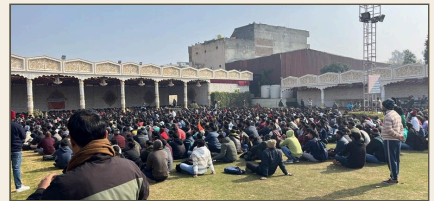
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[1] air-dropped aid that kills.

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[5] Luay Awwad